KINDLE & CLOTH

for a wedding at home

THE BACKYARD WEDDING PLANNING CHECKLIST

The lights come on over the grass, the house is glowing behind the tables, and someone is laughing at the far end of the lawn. That is the evening people mean when they say they want a wedding at home. Getting there is a more practical list than it looks: the yard, the power, the restrooms, a plan if the weather turns, and someone other than the two of you holding the clock. Print this, leave it on the table, and cross things off as you go. You do not need every line.

START HERE

THE FIRST DECISIONS

Get these down before you book a single rental. A real yes on the yard, a guest cap the lawn can hold, and a budget that includes the boring lines will save you from undoing work later.

Our names _____

Wedding date _____

Guest count _____ **Hard cap** _____

The yard (whose, and a real yes) _____

If the weather turns _____

Budget range, including restrooms, power, a tent or other backup, parking, and cleanup

_____

> Here is the thing: the heavy setup belongs on the day before, not the morning of. Chairs, the arch, the tables, the restrooms, the lights. The morning should be finishing, not starting.

02 Twelve months to six months out
03 Five months through the week of, plus a three-month track
04 Rentals, power, restrooms, permits, weather, and neighbors
05 A day-of clock, written from the last goodbye backward
06 The paper guests actually use, and a winter add-on
07 A few guides and the shop, if you want them

A year is a comfortable pace for a wedding at home, not a requirement. If the date is already close, use the three-month track on the next page and skip anything that does not still earn its keep. The early work is the same either way: the legal pieces, the people who book up, and an honest look at the yard.

12–10 MONTHS OUT

Or as soon as you say yes. Enjoy a week first.

- [ ] Agree on a season and a date window, then a day that the yard and the people who have to travel can actually do.
- [ ] Set a guest-count range, and a hard cap the lawn, the parking, and the restrooms can hold.
- [ ] Get a real yes on the yard — whose house, which rooms are in play, and which are not.
- [ ] Write a budget that includes the unglamorous lines: a tent or other weather plan, restrooms, power, parking, insurance, and cleanup. Not only the dress and the dinner.
- [ ] Ask the town about tents, noise, parking, and whether you need a permit. Rules vary; this list is not legal advice.
- [ ] Ask the homeowner's insurance carrier, plainly, what a gathering at the house already covers and what it does not.
- [ ] Book the people who disappear first: the photographer and the officiant.
- [ ] If it is a peak Saturday, start looking at tents and restroom trailers. The good ones go early.
- [ ] Decide, in writing if money is changing hands, who is paying for what — especially at a parent's house.

9–7 MONTHS OUT

This is when the yard stops being an idea and becomes a layout.

- [ ] Walk the yard at the hour you will actually use it. Sketch a ceremony, a dinner, and a third place to stand, with a path that does not go through the kitchen.
- [ ] Measure the lawn, the gate, and the path a delivery truck will use before you sign a rental quote.
- [ ] Decide how people will eat: a caterer, a food truck, a backyard BBQ, family-style, or a dinner you cook.
- [ ] Send save the dates once the date is firm, with a clear address and a note if the house is hard to find.
- [ ] Start a weather plan for rain, heat, and wind, including the time of day you will make the call.
- [ ] Talk with the neighbors — or with the people who have to live there on Monday, if this is a parent's house. Hours, parking, and a contact if something runs late.
- [ ] Choose a person to hold the clock on the day. It should not be the two of you.
- [ ] If music matters, think through a sound system the neighbors and the town can live with.

6 MONTHS OUT

Book the heavy pieces once the guest cap and the layout are real.

- [ ] Reserve the heavy, matching, hard-to-store rentals: tent, tables, chairs, restrooms, and a dance floor if you want one.
- [ ] Lock the food plan, and any gear that comes with it — chafers, glassware, a bar, serving tables.
- [ ] Make a power list (lights, speakers, catering gear, coffee, heaters) and find out what the house can safely run.
- [ ] Plan parking, and a shuttle or an overflow lot if the street cannot take the cars.
- [ ] Begin the invitation: wording, the rain plan in print, and when you will actually send it (often six to eight weeks out).
- [ ] Get delivery, pickup, and damage-waiver terms in writing for every rental.

5–3 MONTHS OUT

The plan gets specific. Stop adding projects that do not help the day.

- ☐ Send the invitations once the date, the address, and the rain plan are in the wording.
- ☐ Confirm restrooms if you are over a small dinner, and that the path to them is firm, lit, and obvious.
- ☐ If the power list is longer than the circuits, arrange a generator or a serious power station, and outdoor-rated cords.
- ☐ Tell the tent company, the officiant, and the photographer what you will do in bad weather, and when you will decide.
- ☐ Design the paper guests will actually hold: a bar menu, place cards, a photo-sharing sign, and a card for the wedding party with timing and where to be.
- ☐ Write a first pass of the day-of timeline, from the last goodbye backward. Pad family photographs and the walk from ceremony to dinner.
- ☐ Share a dress-code note if the yard will be cool, wet, or uneven — people pack better shoes when you tell them.

2–1 MONTHS, THEN THE WEEK OF

Confirm, print, and tell the people next door. Then set up the day before.

- ☐ Confirm the headcount, dietary notes, and every rental delivery and pickup window.
- ☐ Finalize the day-of timeline and give it to the person holding the clock, the photographer, and the officiant.
- ☐ Print the paper, plus a spare bar menu and a few extra place cards.
- ☐ Share hours and parking with the neighbors, and a number to text if something runs late.
- ☐ Gather the small useful things: extension cords, power strips, trash and recycling, ice, tape, a stain kit, bug spray if it is that season, a basket of throws if it will be cool.
- ☐ The day before: set out chairs, the arch, and the tables. Place the restrooms. Test lights and sound. Walk the paths. Put trash cans where people will actually use them.
- ☐ The morning of is for finishing — not starting. Feed the people getting ready. Light the restrooms. Check the power once more.
- ☐ Plan the Monday cleanup, and a thank-you for whoever lent you the yard that is not only a text.

IF YOU ARE GETTING MARRIED IN THREE MONTHS

Three months is enough for a small backyard wedding if you treat it as a short calendar, not a shaved-down year. Book the legal work and tell the people who have to travel. Decide who will eat where, and what you can cook, loan, or rent without a long lead time. Write the invitations once you have the date and the rain plan. Then stop adding projects. A longer version lives here: kindleandcloth.github.io/backyard-wedding-in-three-months

- ☐ **Weeks 1–2.** A real yes on the yard, a guest cap, a budget with the boring lines, town and insurance questions, photographer and officiant if they are still open, and a food plan you can actually pull off.
- ☐ **Weeks 3–6.** Rentals, restrooms, power, a weather plan with a call time, parking, and invitations that already mention the rain plan.
- ☐ **Weeks 7–10.** The paper, a seating plan if you need one, signs, the person holding the clock, and a timeline written from the end of the night backward.
- ☐ **The last two weeks.** Confirmations, printing, a note to the neighbors, setup the day before. If a new idea cannot be finished by then, it does not belong on this wedding.

THE YARD ITSELF

A backyard wedding is not a venue with a banquet captain and a staff hallway. These six lists are the ones that usually decide whether the evening stays calm. Cross off what you have handled, and skip what does not apply — a dinner for thirty does not need the same restroom plan as a Saturday for a hundred.

RENTALS

- [ ] Rent the heavy, matching, hard-to-store pieces: tent, tables, chairs, restrooms, maybe a dance floor.
- [ ] Borrow the back-of-house gear. Buy only what you will keep.
- [ ] Measure the lawn, the gate, and the truck path before you sign a quote.
- [ ] Get delivery, pickup, and the damage waiver in writing.
- [ ] A reserved tent you may not use is almost always calmer than a pretty uncovered lawn with no backup.

More detail: the rentals checklist and tent rental cost.

POWER

- [ ] List everything that will actually plug in: lights, a speaker, catering gear, a coffee pot, a trailer, a heater.
- [ ] A backyard wedding uses more power than a house Saturday. Find out what the circuits can safely run.
- [ ] If the list is longer than the house, bring a generator or a serious power station.
- [ ] Use outdoor-rated cords, and keep them out of the dew and the walkway.
- [ ] Test the whole setup before the day, not an hour before guests arrive.

More detail: how to power a backyard wedding.

RESTROOMS

- [ ] Do not send forty people through one house bathroom.
- [ ] Count the list honestly. Rent a decent unit or a restroom trailer if you are over a small dinner.
- [ ] Place it with a firm path, a light, and a little dignity: soap, a mirror, a trash can.
- [ ] Tell guests where it is — a small sign does more than a mention in a speech.
- [ ] Check it during the evening. Paper, soap, and a bag that is not overflowing.

More detail: when the house bathroom is not enough.

PERMITS & INSURANCE

- [ ] Start with the property and the people next door, then ask the town whether your plans need a permit, a noise exception, or a second look at parking or a tent.
- [ ] Ask your insurance carrier what a gathering at the house already covers, and what it does not.
- [ ] If you are using a parent's house, have that conversation with them, not around them.
- [ ] Write down what you were told, and by whom. This is not legal advice, and it is not a substitute for the rules where you live.

More detail: permits and insurance.

WEATHER PLAN

- [ ] A weather plan is a decision with a time on it, not a hope that the forecast stays pretty.
- [ ] Decide what you will do in rain, in heat, and in wind — shade, a tent, a warm room, or a move indoors.
- [ ] Know when you will make the call, and who is allowed to make it.
- [ ] Tell the tent company, the officiant, and the photographer before the morning of.
- [ ] Put the rain plan on the invitation so you are not explaining it in a dozen texts.

More detail: a weather plan you can actually use.

NEIGHBORS & PARKING

- [ ] Tell the neighbors the hours, where to park, and who to text if something runs late. Inviting them is often the kindest version of that conversation.
- [ ] Walk the parking as it will actually be used. Mark the spots, and have a plan if the street cannot take the cars.
- [ ] Keep a path clear for anyone who still lives in the house, and for emergency access.
- [ ] Leave the street, the yard, and the kitchen as you found them.

More detail: parking and getting married at a parent's house.

WRITE THE DAY BACKWARD

The checklist gets you to the morning of. The day itself stays calm when someone other than the two of you is holding the clock, and when the timeline is written from the last goodbye backward, not from breakfast forward. Pad the two places that always run late: family photographs, and the walk from "the ceremony is over" to "please sit down." A backyard has no staff hallway to hide a delay in. The example on the left is a late-afternoon ceremony in a yard. Slide the hours to fit your day — a morning wedding uses the same padding. The longer version is here: kindleandcloth.github.io/backyard-wedding-day-of-timeline

AN EXAMPLE CLOCK

DAY BEFORE	Chairs, arch, and tables go out. Restrooms are placed. Lights and sound are tested. Paths are walked. The rain plan is confirmed with the person who can actually change it.
MORNING	Finishing, not starting. Feed the people getting ready. Light the restrooms. Check the power. Walk the paths once more.
2:00	Getting ready should be winding down. The yard is already dressed.
4:15	Guests arrive. Parking is marked. The welcome table is set. Someone is there to say hello who is not also steaming a dress.
5:00	Ceremony. Water if it is hot. A seat in the shade if you can. Phones away, if you are asking for that.
5:45	Ceremony ends, and guests move. This walk takes longer in a yard than it does at a venue. Do not schedule dinner at "when the ceremony is over."
6:30	Family photographs. Give this more time than feels polite. It always runs late. Someone other than the couple is gathering the groups.
7:15	Guests sit. A drink, a place card, a clear path to a chair — not a holding pattern on the lawn.
8:00	Dinner should be underway. If it is not, this is usually because photographs or that walk ran long, which is why those two gaps got padding.
9:15	Last dance, or cake, or a late snack people can hold. The restroom still has soap and light.
10:00	Last goodbye. Music down. Food packed. Someone is already starting the cleanup that Monday should not have to finish.

YOUR CLOCK

Who holds the clock _____

_____ Day before, setup done

_____ Morning of, finishing

_____ Getting ready done

_____ Guests arrive

_____ Ceremony

_____ Ceremony ends; guests move

_____ Family photographs (pad this)

_____ Guests sit for dinner

_____ Dinner underway

_____ Cake, last dance, or a late snack

_____ Last goodbye

Write the hours from the last goodbye backward, then fill the gaps. If a row feels tight, it is tight.

> Give this page, your weather plan, and the rental delivery times to the person holding the clock. It should not live only on your phone.

THE PAPER GUESTS ACTUALLY USE

Most of a backyard wedding is things you already own, or things you borrow. The paper is one of the few pieces you have to make on purpose. Guests hold the invitation, they read the bar menu, they find their place card, and they use a sign when you want their photos in one place. If those pieces match, the day feels finished, even when the rest of the yard is just your chairs and some branches.

- ☐ **The invitation.** Date, time, and a clear address, written once. Put the rain plan in the wording so you are not explaining it later. Send it when those facts are actually settled, often six to eight weeks out.
- ☐ **A wedding-party info card.** Timing, where to be, what to wear, and who to text. This saves a long thread the week of.
- ☐ **A bar menu sign.** What is being poured, including something without alcohol, in type people can read from a step or two away.
- ☐ **A photo-sharing sign.** One QR code, one album, so the pictures do not disappear into a group text. Place it where people naturally pause — the welcome table, or near the bar.
- ☐ **Place cards.** Names people will actually recognize, plus a few blanks. A seating plan only helps if finding a chair does not require a speech.
- ☐ **Optional, and useful:** a small parking or restroom sign, a card on the welcome table, a ceremony program if you want one. Skip anything that is only decoration.

We make editable versions of these pieces in two palettes you can finish in Canva — Winter Evergreen, and a cream, sage, and terracotta backyard set — plus a winter wonderland suite if that is more your evening. Nothing ships. You add your wording and print at home or at a shop. They are all on our wedding templates page, and on the last page of this checklist.

A WINTER OR HOLIDAY ADD-ON

If you are marrying in December, January, or around Christmas, the yard can still be part of the day. The outdoor part stays short, and there has to be a warm room that can actually hold everyone. Heat the reception, not just the photographs. For a Christmas wedding at home, use what is already in the house — the tree, the lights, the evergreen on the mantel — and then stop decorating. Tell guests, early, how the holiday and the wedding share a weekend. Longer reads: a Christmas wedding at home and winter backyard wedding ideas.

- ☐ Plan around early dusk. The ceremony or the photographs may need to start sooner than a summer Saturday.
- ☐ Walk the paths as they will be that night. Ice, mud, and a dark side yard are how people get hurt, not how they remember the lights.
- ☐ Set out throws, hand warmers, and a way to get inside that does not need a speech about it.
- ☐ If part of the day is outdoors, keep it brief, then move people to a room that is actually warm.
- ☐ Choose a menu that can sit out for a little while, or a way to keep it hot. A pretty plate that goes cold is not a favor.
- ☐ Tell the neighbors the hours, especially on a holiday weekend when the street is already full.
- ☐ Put a coat plan near the door. A bed in a back room works if you tell people it is there.
- ☐ Have an indoor backup that can hold the whole list, not a pretty porch that holds twelve.

if you want a little more help

This list is from Kindle & Cloth. The blog is a set of practical guides for backyard, winter, and at-home weddings. We also make editable paper templates when you want the invitation, the bar menu, the place cards, and a sign for photos to match. Take what is useful. Leave the rest.

FROM THE SHOP

EDITABLE TEMPLATES, IN THE PALETTES WE ALREADY USE

Nothing ships. You download a file, add your wording, and print at home or at a shop. The rustic backyard bundle is cream, sage, and terracotta — the same colors as this checklist — and it holds the invitation, a bar menu sign, a bridesmaid info card, a photo-sharing sign, and place cards, together. If you are planning a December, January, or Christmas wedding, the Winter Evergreen suite is pine, burgundy berries, and white anemones on ivory.

- ☐ **The rustic backyard bundle** — kindleandclothco.etsy.com/listing/4615097608
- ☐ **The Winter Evergreen bundle** — kindleandclothco.etsy.com/listing/4615156837

Single pieces and a winter wonderland suite live with them on our templates page: kindleandcloth.github.io/wedding-templates. The shop itself is kindleandclothco.etsy.com.

FROM THE BLOG

A backyard wedding day-of timeline
The longer clock, and why those two gaps need padding.

How to plan a backyard wedding in three months
A short calendar, not a shorter version of a long one.

Just engaged at the holidays
A 2027 backyard timeline for the first ninety days.

A Christmas wedding at home
Using what is already in the house, then stopping.

A backyard wedding weather plan
A decision with a time on it, for rain, heat, and wind.

More guides on the blog
Or start at the search page if you already know the question.

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Print a second copy for the person holding the clock. You'll thank yourself.